

4

Strategizing

In the last chapter, on narrative, I focused on the “why” question: why we feel the way we do about things, a matter of the heart. In the next chapter, on action, I focus on the “what” question: what we do about things, a matter of the hands. In this chapter, on strategy, I focus on the “how” question: how we think about things, a matter of the head.

Although I grew up like many, I suspect, strategizing to get what I wanted, I only began to learn strategic craft when I began to do it: in the civil rights movement, in the UFW, and in the world of electoral politics. Sometimes it worked, other times it didn’t, but learning from success and failure informs the craft of strategizing.

As I recounted in the Introduction, one goal of the Mississippi Summer Project was to support the organizing of the Mississippi Freedom Democratic Party (MFDP). We would go to the Democratic National Convention in Atlantic City in August to demand that the Freedom Democrats be seated to replace the segregated—and all-white—delegation sent by the racist Mississippi Democratic Party.

Our focus was clear: organize in Mississippi, mobilize for Atlantic City, and impact our politics nationally. We could win the freedom to organize in Mississippi at the same time. The leadership of the Summer Project had linked who we were, what we would do, and the outcome we could achieve—strategy! Even though the summer began tragically with the murders of Chaney, Schwerner, and Goodman—and much other violence—we achieved our initial objective: we organized 80,000 people to register with the MFDP. By August, thirty-eight local chapters had held precinct caucuses, county caucuses, and a state convention where they elected a slate of sixty-eight delegates headed by Ms. Fannie Lou Hamer. Ms. Hamer was a courageous, passionate, and powerfully eloquent organizer from the Mississippi Delta who had endured unspeakable violence at the hands of the local authorities when she tried to register to vote.

For support, we had organized sympathetic Democratic convention delegates from California, Wisconsin, and across the country. Our outreach

to the nation began with Ms. Hamer's widely televised testimony before the Credentials Committee. But she only got halfway through her riveting account when the cameras shut down. President Lyndon Johnson, who had been watching her testimony, suddenly called an emergency press conference in the White House Rose Garden. Despite the righteousness of our cause, the president, fearful of alienating Southern Democrats in November, had decided to stop the MFDP. After the press conference, he assigned vice presidential nominee Senator Hubert Humphrey, a very well-credentialed liberal, to disorganize our support. Within hours, our allies began to withdraw one by one. They had been threatened with political reprisals, loss of their jobs, and exclusion from subsequent Democratic Party activities.

We lost.

Despite an MFDP sit-in on the convention floor with borrowed credentials, some organizers gave in to despair. Others gave over to rage. Affirmed in their cynicism, some were content to denounce the system with greater vehemence. But others—me included, along with most of the MFDP delegation—learned a critical lesson about power: Just as might doesn't make right, right doesn't make might. Enabling right to make might is what strategy can be all about. Or as theologian Paul Tillich taught, power without love can never be just, but love without power can never achieve justice.¹

What Is Strategy?

Strategy is how you turn what you have into what you need to get what you want. We all know how to do this. If you have ever overslept, missed your bus, and needed to get to work or school on time, you crafted a plan B or a work-around. Whether you called a Lyft, borrowed a bike, called on a friend with a car, or something else, you were strategizing—figuring out how to turn the resources you had into the power, or capacity, you needed to get what you want. Like storytelling, we strategize every day. We are purposeful creatures who come up with plans for the next few minutes, the next hour, the next day, and the next year. Because the world is a contingent place, a place of continual change, some intended, some not, some random, some not, reality often disrupts our plans. It's not that the plan was bad (unless it didn't allow for change), but the future is uncertain. So implicitly, if not explicitly, we learn to strategize throughout our lives.

The word “strategy” comes from the Greek *stratos*—the word for army based on *strateo*, spreading out, like on a field of battle—and *agein*—the word for leading. The general was called *strategos*, an army leader. The *strategos* would go to the top of a hill and evaluate the resources on both sides; reflect on opportunities and constraints imposed by the battlefield, the time of day, the strengths and limitations of his own troops and those of his opponent; and consider how to deploy his troops in ways most likely to achieve victory. The *strategos* needed a good overview of the field, as well as intimate knowledge of each army’s capacities, and details of the streams, bridges, forests, trees, and overall terrain. Another way to describe what the *strategos* does is to hypothesize a theory of change: how to get from here, a moment of uncertainty, to where we need to be, which is winning.

The soldiers down on the field were described as *taktikos*, skilled in the art of arrangement, putting things in order, or deployment. They were the ones who had to translate the theory of the *strategos* into action (Figure 4.1).



Figure 4.1 Strategy and Tactics. Source: Steve Downer of the Difference

Tactics are the specific actions through which strategy is embodied and enacted. An activity, from shooting an arrow to hosting a house meeting, to organizing a rally, is not a tactic unless it is strategic: implementing and at the same time testing a theory of change. Launching a petition, for example, or any action done because “that’s what we always do” is not a tactic because it is not strategic. When people describe recent mobilizations as tactics in search of a strategy, they are describing habitual or reactive activities uninformed by any theory of change.

Strategy is not big or tactics, small. They are different. We strategize to develop a hypothesis about how we could use our resources to achieve valued change: a “theory of change.” A theory of change, in turn, can guide our choices about targeting, timing, and tactics. On what do we focus, targeting deployment of our resources to get the most leverage: a strategic goal? How can we harmonize the temporal rhythm of our campaign with that of the world around us, as well as our personal rhythms? When do we start, when do we stop, do we go fast or slow, short term or long term? How do we deploy tactics to implement our theory of change and, at the same time, test it, adapt it, or even change it based on new learning?

Strategizing is also highly contextualized in a unique way. It requires seeing trees and forest at the same time. The *strategos* on the hilltop has a great overview. The *taktikos* in the valley has an intimate view of the field of battle. The problem is when a fog may settle between the hilltop and the valley. The *strategos* imagines he knows the whole truth. The *taktikos* imagines that he knows the whole truth. Strategizing requires both truths—intimate knowledge of the context along with a capacity to put the context in context.

Learning to Strategize

Having learned the importance of strategy, my real training in strategic craft began in the UFW. One of Cesar Chavez’s real gifts—rooted in the street smarts that came with needing to do a lot with a little—was his ability to strategize. I was in awe of it. But this gift only became a strength of the UFW because Cesar shared it, engaged others in it, and challenged others to learn it. So, the UFW became a venue in which many of us learned to strategize. Cesar blended his street smarts with study of the lives of the saints, ten years of organizing with Fred Ross and Saul Alinsky, Gandhi’s teachings evident in the civil rights movement, a mastery of cultural resources, and

a commitment to constant adaptive learning. If civic associations were, according to Tocqueville, “great free schools of democracy,” then the UFW was a great free school of strategy.

The question of power was central to our work, a legacy of Alinsky’s focus on power. But this was power based on people, not money. We strategized within four venues: strikes, boycotts, politics, and the law. We contested the growers for power in each venue. Our primary source of power was our constituency, their depth of commitment, their hopefulness, and their readiness to sacrifice. We organized a secondary source of power in our urban supporters who could organize grape boycotts by stopping supermarkets from selling them. We learned to manage alliances within the labor movement, the churches, liberals, and the Latino world without losing our own autonomy: we drew resources from each of them without falling into dependency on any one of them. My own assignment from 1968 to 1970 and 1973 to 1975 was to organize Canadians to stop buying California grapes in Toronto and Montreal, the third- and fifth-largest grape markets in North America, respectively. Organizing in Canada also gave me a uniquely valuable opportunity to learn how unions, politics, and democratic government could work far better than they did here at home.

Although the challenges were great, figuring out how to turn lemons into lemonade can also be fun. Cesar used to love carom shots—as in pool, when you hit one ball to move another—and enjoyed talking about “killing two birds with one stone and keeping the stone.” My school of strategizing was in this setting of widely diverse cultural, political, and economic contexts. We learned to do community organizing, workplace organizing, urban boycott organizing, and electoral organizing.

Our Pilgrimage to Sacramento was timed to coincide with the Schenley boycott, and with a visit to the city of Delano by Senator Bobby Kennedy, inspired by Dr. King’s Selma-to-Montgomery march, and aligned with the Lenten season and resulted in our first contract. Cesar’s fast for nonviolence defanged growers’ claims of union violence, gave our grape boycott a critical boost, and recommitted everyone in the movement to a longer, deeper, and more disciplined struggle. The grape boycott itself enabled supporters across North America to translate their moral support into real economic power. Learning how this worked was my second school of strategy.

After I left the UFW in 1981, I found a third school of strategy in the world of California electoral politics. I was introduced to electoral organizing in the 1968 Robert Kennedy for President campaign and had worked on three

of Jerry Brown's campaigns (one gubernatorial [1978] and two presidential [1976 and 1980]), but my technical learning began with San Francisco political consultant Clint Reilly. Clint had entered and dropped out of a Roman Catholic seminary, and his first campaign was trying to elect a Bay Area peace candidate, the priest who had been his mentor. He had also supported the UFW in a 1972 campaign to recall the governor of Arizona. By 1982, Clint had emerged as a Bay Area campaign pro who also recognized that organizing skills—volunteer recruitment, leadership development, and voter mobilization—could be of real value in campaigns. His experiment with organizing tactics began by working with former UFW organizers Larry Tramutola, Scott Washburn, and Fred Ross, Jr. to conduct a house meeting drive that thwarted an attempt to recall then-mayor Dianne Feinstein and, instead, solidified her political base.

"Studying" with Clint, I learned to set vote goals, distinguish motivation from persuasion, segment the electorate by likelihood of voting, and use digital technology to enhance the effectiveness of electoral organizing. California was far ahead of the rest of the country in digitizing voter information. This had contributed to a narrowed focus on most-likely voters—who tended to be older, whiter, and richer—while marginalizing everyone else. But in the 1983 San Diego mayoral election, we devised an "occasional voter" strategy. We could identify the people who always voted and recruit them to join us in organizing their neighbors who were identified as only voting occasionally. We could provide them with lists of the names, addresses, and phone numbers of each occasional voter in their precinct. Instead of having us try to motivate four hundred or five hundred people in a precinct, these precinct leaders could focus on eighty or ninety voters for whom it might make a real difference. We could focus on Latino and Black precincts where voters generally supported our candidates but voter turnout was low. Instead of persuasion, we would focus on motivation. This approach to combining sophisticated digital targeting with solid grassroots organizing would, years later, inform the Obama campaign.

Years later in the 1990s when working on my PhD in sociology, I was happy to find that a study of the farmworker movement had become part of the social movement canon. But I was shocked to find that this then-classic article by J. Craig Jenkins and Charles Perrow argued that the UFW's victories—victories in which I had played a part—could be explained by

the conditions (opportunities, resources) at the time, not by anything we had done!²

This turned out to be a microcosm of a much larger problem in the social movement literature, which focused mainly on conditions that made movements probable rather than on leadership who finds ways to figure out how to make the improbable possible. Yet this move, of making the improbable possible, is at the heart of strategic leadership practice, especially in highly volatile social movement settings. How this imaginative process works became the focus of my master's thesis, my first academic article, called "Resources and Resourcefulness" (2000), and eventually, my dissertation, and finally my book *Why David Sometimes Wins* (2009).

How Strategy Works

Strategizing, like storytelling, is a verb. We strategize in the present, relying on what we've learned from the past and imagining a future that remains unknown. Strategizing is the practice of adapting to unexpected opportunities and challenges far more than it is planning and implementing the plan. As organization scholar Henry Mintzberg describes it, strategy is like a potter interacting with the clay on the wheel.³ Although our goal remains clear, we are (or should be) constantly adapting to new information: sudden opportunities or obstacles, change in the resource in the environment, the actions and reactions of others, discoveries about our own limitations and capabilities.

Strategy, like music, only exists in time. That's what makes strategy dynamic: opportunities—or obstacles—may occur suddenly. The same resources may acquire greater or lesser value not because of anything we do but because of a change in the context. A full granary, for example, acquires greater value in a famine, affording greater power for its owner. A close election creates opportunity for political leaders who can influence swing voters. A labor shortage creates opportunities for workers to get more for their labor.

Strategy, finally, is dynamic because the actions and reactions of others, especially when oppositional, alter the environment. In contexts where rules, resources, and interests are fixed, we may use analytic tools such as game theory to inform our strategizing. But in settings where rules, resources, and interests are emergent, ambiguous and contested—such as

social movements—strategizing becomes more of an exercise in creative, yet grounded, imagination. Strategizing is a creative, dynamic, and agile process of adapting intentional action in response to ever changing conditions. It is a motivated, intentional, proactive, creative, and nested practice.

Strategy Is Motivated

We strategize, as with storytelling, in response to immediate or anticipated disruption. Stories provide the emotional resources to meet the challenge of responding hopefully rather than reacting fearfully. We strategize in response to the cognitive challenge of learning how to turn the resources at hand into the power we need to achieve our goals. Because we are creatures of habit, we are usually only motivated to tell stories or devise strategy when there is a problem to be solved. Only then, because we must, do we pay attention, look around, and decide what we must do. Storytelling facilitates our emotional response by reminding us of our “why.” Strategizing facilitates our cognitive response by opening a pathway to our “how.”

Strategy Is Intentional

We strategize to respond to disruption with intentionality. Our purpose may be, for instance, to achieve educational equity. But how can we do it? Finding possible answers requires analysis and a deeply rooted understanding of context: who we are, where we are, and when we are. The challenge is specific: figuring how our specific “us” can turn specific resources into the specific power we need to achieve specific goals aligned with our purpose. We may learn of a suitable program but also learn that enacting it would require funds from our school board that, even if they supported it, they don’t have. In that case, the first step may be to organize voters to approve a school bond, but to do that we may need the support of the school board. Both may depend on organizing the broader community to show visible support early on. To do that, we’ll have to engage with parents who may want greater equity for their kids—for those who have less as well as those who have more. So we would be wise to base our campaign on well-organized, vocal, and diverse community support, which may, in turn, require developing new leadership who can give this cause the attention it needs. This practice is intentional

because it is grounded in deep understanding of the entire context, including ourselves.

Strategy Is Proactive

There are two common ways we operate in the world: we can be reactive, as many organizations are, or we can be proactive. Even when we are strategizing in response to a new challenge, we can be proactive by sequencing the timing of our campaign goals to retain the initiative, enhance our capacity, build momentum, and take advantage of moments of opportunity. Initial tactics can be chosen to yield resources in the beginning that can be deployed toward the end. As we reach a peak—a point at which we've created a new capacity—we can begin to employ new tactics. Most campaigns must devote an initial chunk of time to recruiting enough volunteers to create the critical mass needed to recruit supporters on a large enough scale. This is what builds momentum. Each success contributes new resources, which make the next success more achievable.

When we strategize, we give a voice to a possible future, enabling it to make claims on the present. This requires the courage to say no to current demands to commit to an uncertain future. When we must choose how to invest scarce resources, voices of present constituencies speak loudly, even though they were created by choices in the past. The voices of future constituencies are silent. Trying to shape the future may require choices that could involve substantial risk in the present. The first step in shaping the future, however, is to engage others in imagining it—and then to find the courage to act on our imagination.

Strategy Is Creative

Strategy is a form of street smarts: figuring out how to do a lot with a little, adapting to disruptions or the moves of your opponent, and doing so quickly, imaginatively, and effectively. In virtually every culture there is a story of how, against all the odds, the “little guy” beat the “big guy.” Defeating an opponent by deploying overwhelming force stirs little interest or lessons in strategy—unless we ask how that overwhelming force was assembled or how the force was positioned in a spot where it could be overwhelming. Classic strategists

include Odysseus in Greece, Momotarō in Japan, Zhou Yu in China, and many others. In the West, pride of place goes to the biblical story of David and Goliath.⁴

When Goliath, veteran warrior and victor of many battles, challenges the Israelites in full battle gear, their military leaders cower in fear. It is David, the young shepherd boy whom God has anointed, who finds the courage to face the giant. David's success begins with his motivation, commitment, and courage, but it takes more than courage to bring David success. The king's advice is to use the conventional tools of battle—sword, shield, and helmet—of which Goliath, not David, is master. David, showing proper respect for the king, takes the advice. But the sword, shield, and helmet are too heavy for him. He can't move.

That's when David begins to see the battle through different eyes: his eyes, the eyes of a shepherd, not those of a warrior. Noticing five small stones in a wadi at his feet, he reflects on previous challenges protecting his flock from bears and lions. Realizing Goliath might be “just another bear, just another lion,” he reframes the battle in a new way that gives him an advantage based on resources he does have—five smooth stones and his skill with a sling—as well as his opponent's self-satisfied arrogance. “Am I a dog,” Goliath says, “that you send a boy with a stick?” And at that moment, he gets David's stone in his forehead . . . and it's the end of Goliath. Surely it is not a story about nonviolence, but it is a story about strategy, the difference between resources and power, and the way the creative use of novel resources can compensate for the business-as-usual use of conventional resources. In other words, one way to compensate for imbalance in resources is with greater resourcefulness, like moving the fulcrum on which the balance, or imbalance, rests. Good strategists learn to get more leverage from resources that are available. Power is thus not simply a matter of resources, but also of the resourcefulness with which those resources are used.⁵

Strategy Is Nested

Although our goals to change the world—restructure US health care to make it cheap, accessible, and of quality by 2030; create a carbon-neutral world by 2050; visibly reverse the galloping economic inequality by 2025—may be (necessarily) ambitious, rarely do we have the power to achieve them at this moment. We may be wise to persuade the local mayor and city council to

commit to a less ambitious goal on their own. If we do the same thing in twenty other cities within our state, we are not only broadening our political support, but we are also building a statewide organization that can enhance our power by many times (Figure 4.2).

To elect a president of the United States, we will need 270 electoral votes to win. How can we get them? In which states must we campaign to get those votes? Some states will go for us or for our opponent, no matter what. If only about eight states could go either way, we need to figure out how to win those states. We must look at each state and ask very similar questions: which counties, towns, or even precincts do we need to win? Just as each goal is nested within a larger goal, we must look at our resources and our goal, and figure out how we can use our resources to achieve that goal. It works the same way with time. How many voters do we need to get out to vote on Election Day? To get that number, how many commitments do I need to have two weeks before Election Day, and so on?

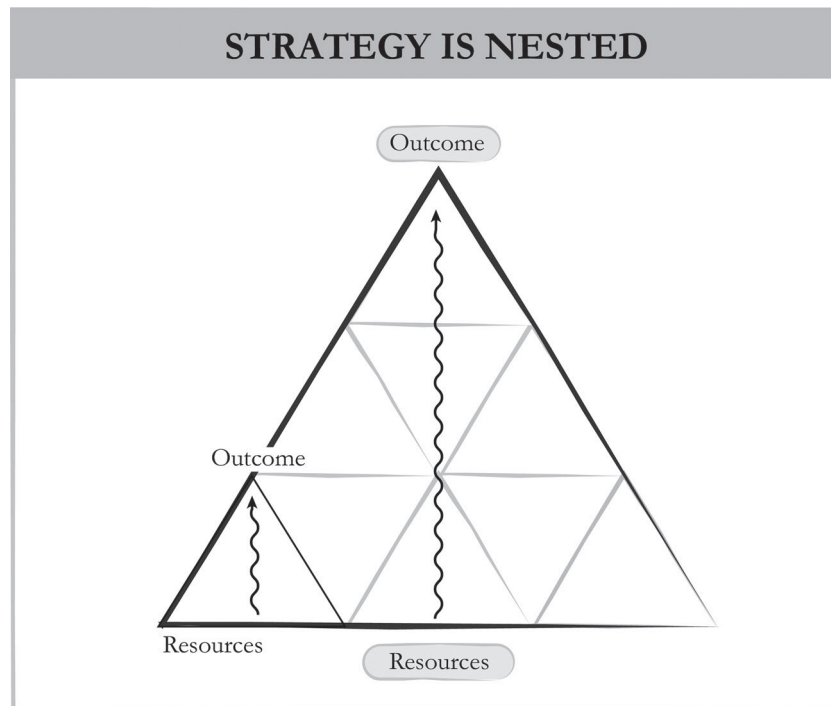


Figure 4.2 Strategy Is Nested. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Although the scale (space) and scope (time) vary for different goals, the strategic process is the same, whether I want to have a great first meeting or elect a new president: turning what I have into what I need to get what I want.

Practicing Strategy: Who, When, and How?

Who Strategizes?

Because strategizing is sustained creative work that particular people do in particular contexts at particular moments, who strategizes matters. It matters as much as the musicians playing a jazz set, the players on the soccer field, or Kierkegaard's pilot traversing a stormy sea. It also matters because particular people are responsible for leading the creative adaptation that strategizing requires. Yet most observers focus more on what a good strategy is, rather than how good strategy is generated, when, and by whom. So, the question of who strategizes, and under what conditions, is the first question we ask.

I learned this painfully when I was coaching the new leader of a major Southern California union on strategy. We met regularly. We often included members of his team. And we would come up with interesting, exciting, and creative strategies. But nothing would ever come of them. After an especially frustrating session, I finally got it. I was imagining strategy *I* could make work. But it was the leader I was coaching who was responsible for making it work, not me. He was the one who had to adapt whatever strategy we came up with to make it work. This was not a matter of intelligence, commitment, or motivation. His experience was not my experience, nor was my experience his. He was accountable in ways I was not. He was the one who had to navigate ever-present political shoals. Strategizing is such a contextualized, creative, and interactive process that it is only done when the campaign is done. Strategizing, like any sustained creative endeavor, is a creature of the creator or creators.

Insiders and Outsiders

An insider may have information needed to strategize, but as we saw in the David-and-Goliath story, it was David, the young shepherd, not one of the seasoned warriors, his brothers, who rose to the occasion and devised the winning strategy. As an outsider, he saw possibilities the insiders, the warriors, could not see, in part because he had to. He recognized the value

of his unique resources, was skilled in how to use them, and was aware of his opponent's weakness, his arrogance.

Strategizing thus often requires a combination of insider and outsider perspectives—whether in the same person or in a leadership team. People may be insiders in one way but outsiders in another. In Alabama, Dr. King was an insider in terms of race and religion but an outsider in terms of class, education, networks, and much more.

Personal Motivation

Highly motivated people can strategize creatively, skillfully, and effectively. Experiencing our work as a vocation or a calling motivates us. And motivation, in turn, can encourage focus, concentration, persistence, readiness to risk, and energy. Motivation may move us to do the work to get the knowledge and skills we need to do what we want to do well. People who are intensely committed to solving a particular problem, who are dissatisfied with the status quo, or who experience breaches in their expectations are also more likely to think outside the box.⁶

Motivation also influences strategy with respect to the sources of one's power. If I think my power depends on resources held by my constituency, and if empowering my constituency is one of my goals, I will do what's necessary to sustain constituency engagement. If, alternatively, I think my power depends on resources held by my donors, I will do what's needed to sustain donor engagement. Successes, even small ones, not only can generate more resources. They can also generate greater motivation.

Strategy Teams

Although good strategy is often portrayed as the fruit of a strategic genius, more often it is the work of a good strategic team a good leader has assembled. The leadership team of the Montgomery Bus Boycott, for example, included a seamstress/organizer who rode the buses, a respected local preacher whose congregants rode the buses, an experienced member of the Brotherhood of Sleeping Car Porters who put his learning to work in the community, the leader of an academic women's group at the local Black college, the only Black lawyer in town, and a very young minister of a local church, so new to the community that he did not have enough history for anyone to object to his being there, one M. L. King Jr.

Strategizing in a team can be more creative, well grounded, and motivational than strategizing alone. Innovative thinking is facilitated by

encounters with diverse points of view, whether based on the life experience of individuals or diversity of experience within a group. Access to a diversity of salient knowledge not only offers multiple routines from which to choose but also contributes to the awareness of the fact that multiple solutions are possible. Perhaps the most important criterion for a strategy team, then, is that it has a combination of people who have learned, or are open to learning, that there is more than one way to look at things.

Organizing relies on the resources, engagement, and leadership drawn from one's constituency. It is, of course, fundamental that any strategic team include members of that constituency, as well as those who are not members of that constituency.

How Do We Strategize?

Good strategizing often begins with critical reflection on our own assumptions, testing them against our experience, against the evidence, against the perception of others, and against internal contradictions. This can be very frightening even as it can be exhilarating. We see the world through lenses or models shaped by our experiences that both enable and constrain. These lenses enable us to make sense of things, generalize, make choices, draw conclusions, and act. But they can also inhibit our perception, limiting what we see to what we expect to see, and making it difficult for us to learn.⁷ Creative thinking requires recognizing our problems as new ones—at least to us—that require new solutions. The Zen practice of *shoshin*—approaching tasks with a beginner's mind—recognizes that openness to new learning can require substantial unlearning.⁸

Obtaining clarity on the facts often requires challenging dominant paradigms or beliefs about how the world works and which typically align with status quo interests. This too calls for the kind of agitation described in the last chapter: surfacing contradictions that people may not have considered or have avoided. The process is uncomfortable, to be sure, but can create the tension needed to break free of the status quo.⁹

Challenging others to consider a different interpretation requires engaging them in critical reflection. Explaining something again and again will change nothing unless the beliefs through which the explanation is filtered are changed as well. While storytelling is an essential tool in tapping into shared

values and activating agency, strategizing is not storytelling. Strategizing is about making an argument, about “if-then” hypotheses.

Strategizing well in a team requires intentionally creating a “holding environment,” a brave space in which we can learn, treat failure as informative, suspend judgement, ask for help, solve problems, and experience supportive challenge and affirmation. This requires building relationships among participants and their agreement on explicit ground rules and norms of mutual respect that encourage trust, risk taking, learning, and imagination. This was a real strength in the UFW for many years. Our strategy team was diverse in many ways and its members embedded in critical constituencies. Among our nine members were farmworkers, immigrants, citizens; Mexicans, Filipinos, Anglos, and Blacks; Jews, Catholics, and people with no religious affiliation; pastors, a lawyer, women, and men; young people and elders. When we strategized well, and quickly, it was in a spirit of mutual respect, learning, experimentation, and humor. We had a clear decision-making process. And when we didn’t strategize as well, we needed time to repair and recover.

When Do We Strategize?

Although strategizing is an ongoing activity, it often begins with strategic planning. A key element of strategic planning is to decide on a specific goal—targeting. Planning can help clarify choices that must be made to begin and in enabling those responsible to arrive at a common vision of where they want to go and how they hope to get there. But a plan is a hypothesis, not a blueprint. As such, paying close attention to the early moments when the rubber hits the road is critically important for discovering false assumptions and missed opportunities. This also requires a capacity to observe what’s happening with enough granularity to learn from it. Or as General Eisenhower put it, “In preparing for battle I have always found that plans are useless, but planning is indispensable.”¹⁰

Another very important time for restrategizing is at the midpoint of a project or campaign.¹¹ Research on organizational culture shows that groups tend to persist as they began, avoiding interventions, until the midpoint, when a realization that less time remains than has elapsed creates a receptivity to fresh analysis (not unlike a midlife crisis). This is the case regardless of whether the project is for three days or three years. By planning for a

midpoint evaluation, leaders can take strategic advantage of this natural phenomenon. Groups also tend to reorganize for the endgame, the final stages of the project, when focus on the here and now can be especially critical.

In organizing, the real action is often, as Alinsky put it, in the reaction—by other actors, the opposition, and the challenges and opportunities that emerge along the way.¹² The mindfulness we bring to bear on our choices relative to what we want to achieve can make our response strategic and not simply reactive. An important enabler of this mindfulness is a stance of curiosity rather than fear, as we saw in the chapter on narrative.

Finally, consciousness that we learn not only for the present but also for the future means that a first step in subsequent strategizing is a fresh, clear, and objective analysis of what happened this time and why, win or lose. Although we often describe this debriefing as “pluses, deltas and takeaways” the military calls this “After Action Report (AAR)”.

The Strategic Process: Six Questions

Although any multistep process is more useful as a road map than as a blueprint, it can help scaffolding learning. When someone begins learning to drive, a checklist is very helpful, indeed, necessary. But at some point, the person becomes a driver who has mastered the process enough to adapt, innovate, and invent. In Japanese martial arts this is called *shuhari*: *shu* is the master’s way; *ha* is the way of adaptation; and *ri*, the way of creation. We ought not to confuse the scaffold with the practice, turning the scaffold into a checklist from which we must not deviate. The following is one way to translate these considerations into a six-step process we can use to scaffold strategizing an organizing campaign. The framework we’ll use consists of six questions: (1) Who are my people? (2) What is the change they want? (3) What is their theory of change? (4) What is their strategic goal? (5) What tactics can we use? and (6) What’s the timing?

Trying to learn to strategize in the abstract is like trying to learn how to play music without a particular instrument. We will explore each of these questions in the context of the UFW’s campaign to win its first real contract (1965/6).

It was February 1966, in Delano, California. Grape workers had been on strike for union recognition for five months. In November, the season had ended with no breakthroughs. A boycott called in December against

Schenley Industries, a major liquor company with 4,000 acres of grapes, had produced no results. So Chavez convened a meeting of leadership at a supporter's home near Santa Barbara to devote three days to figuring out how to move on Schenley, prepare for the spring, and sustain the commitment of strikers, organizers, and supporters. I quote from my notes of that meeting:

As proposals flew around the room, someone suggested we follow the example of the New Mexico miners who had traveled to New York to set up a mining camp in front of the company headquarters on Wall Street. Farmworkers could travel to Schenley headquarters in New York, set up a labor camp out front, and maintain a vigil until Schenley signed. Someone else then suggested they go by bus to hold rallies across the country, organize local boycott committees, and generate publicity, building momentum for the arrival in New York. Then why not march instead of going by bus, someone else asked, as Dr. King had the previous year? But it's too far from Delano to New York, someone countered. On the other hand, the Schenley headquarters in San Francisco might not be too far—about 280 miles, which an army veteran present calculated could be done at the rate of 15 miles a day, or in about 20 days.

*“But what if Schenley doesn't respond?” Chavez asked. Why not march to Sacramento instead and put the heat on Governor Brown to intervene and get negotiations started? He's up for reelection and wants the votes of our supporters, so perhaps we can have more impact if we use him as leverage. Yes, someone else said, and on the way to Sacramento, the march could pass through most of the farmworker towns. Taking a page from Mao's “long march,” we could organize local committees and get workers to sign pledges not to break the strike. Yes, and we could also get them to feed us and house us. And just as Zapata wrote his “Plan de Ayala,” Luis Valdez suggested, we can write a “Plan de Delano,” read it in each town, ask local farmworkers to sign it and to carry it to the next town. Then, Chavez asked, why should it be a “march” at all? It will be Lent soon, a time for reflection, for penance, for asking forgiveness. Perhaps ours should be a pilgrimage, a *perigrinación*, which could arrive at Sacramento on Easter Sunday.*

On March 17, farmworkers began their *perigrinación*, carrying banners of Our Lady of Guadalupe, patron saint of Mexico; portraits of campesino leader Emiliano Zapata; placards proclaiming, “Perigrinación, Penitencia, Revolución”—Pilgrimage, Penance, Revolution—and signs calling on supporters to boycott Schenley. One striker, Roberto Roman, carried a

six-foot-tall wooden cross constructed of two-by-fours and draped in black cloth. Timed to coincide with a visit by Senator Bobby Kennedy for the US Senate Subcommittee on Migratory Labor hearings in Delano, the march attracted public attention from the start. Televised images of a line of helmeted police temporarily blocking the marchers' departure evoked images of police lines in Selma, Alabama, the year before. A crowd of more than one thousand welcomed the marchers to Fresno at the end of the first week. Reporters profiled strikers, asking them why they would walk three hundred miles, and analyzed what the strike was all about. The march articulated not only the farmworkers' call for justice but also the Mexican American community's claims for a voice in public life. At an individual level, as Cesar Chavez described it, the march was also a way of "training ourselves to endure the long, long struggle, which by this time had become evident. . . . We wanted to be fit not only physically but also spiritually."¹³

On the afternoon of April 3, as the farmworkers arrived in Stockton, a week's march south of Sacramento, Schenley's lawyer reached Chavez by phone. Schenley had little interest in remaining the object of a boycott, especially as the march's arrival in Sacramento promised to become a national anti-Schenley rally. As a result, just three days before the march would arrive, Schenley signed the first real union contract in California farm labor history. So, on Saturday afternoon, a crowd that had grown to two thousand gathered on the grounds of Our Lady of Grace School in West Sacramento, on a hill looking across the Sacramento River to the capital city that they would enter the next morning. During the Easter vigil service that evening, more than one speaker compared them to the ancient Israelites camped across the River Jordan from the Land of Promise. That night, Roberto Roman carefully rewrapped his cross in white and decorated it with spring flowers. The next morning, barefoot, he bore it triumphantly across the river bridge, down the state capitol mall, and up the capitol steps where he was met by a crowd of ten thousand farmworkers and supporters who launched the farmworker movement.

Question 1: Who Are My People?

The first question an organizer asks is not "What is my issue?" but "Who are my people?" In organizing your people benefit from their own success and only secondarily from your success. Their power will not grow—nor

will any power have shifted—unless fundamentally rooted in their commitment of their own resources. People’s use of their own resources is what distinguishes a constituency from customers or clients. Organizing is about enabling people to collaborate in developing their own power to solve their own problems. Unless “your people” experience their own agency and the power to act on it, sustained change is unlikely.

So, we start with learning the values, interests, resources, networks, and conditions of our people. As an old union organizer tried to teach us, “Nothing beats sticking close to the people.” So, if your people are to be motivated to organize, their motivation will be rooted in their lived experience of the problem—and how it could be different—in their daily lives. The difference between a segregated bus, for example, and a desegregated one. Working with people to do something about climate change becomes far more urgent if about recovery from last year’s flood. This is not a time for polling or focus groups but rather for lots of one-on-one meetings. We far too often make assumptions about what people want without asking, only to be surprised they don’t show up.

In the UFW case, who were the people? Although the UFW wanted to organize all farmworkers everywhere in the United States, its primary constituency was farmworker families who worked in the table grape industry. Some had joined the UFW before the strike, but most signed up with the UFW only after going on strike. This constituency gradually grew to include farmworkers in other regions of the state and in other crops. In addition, once the strike began, the UFW set to organizing a secondary constituency who did not work in the fields but supported both the strike and the broader movement, which came to be known as “La Causa.” This included several young people who came to Delano and volunteered to serve on the picket lines. But most lived elsewhere and included students, union people, community leaders, members of faith communities, members of the Mexican and Mexican American communities, civil rights groups, political liberals, and so on—a network not unlike the constituency for the civil rights movement.

By December 1965, the active core of the organization’s primary constituency was the one hundred to two hundred farmworkers and their families who remained in the area after the end of the season, serving full time on the picket lines, managing the food donations, fixing the cars, and otherwise sustaining the strike, now known as “La Huelga.” Because of the relatively long table grape season, some lived in the area; others came seasonally; and still others came only at the peak. The core of the UFW leadership team

had been a board elected by the members prior to the strike and included Cesar Chavez, Gilberto Padilla, Dolores Huerta, Antonio Orendain, Julio Hernandez, and Roger Terronez. They called the shots in collaboration with the leadership of the Filipino workers affiliated with the AFL-CIO who had started the strike. Chavez was born in the United States near the Mexican border to an immigrant farming family who became migrants when the farm was lost in the Depression. He served in the navy, went to work in a lumber mill, and, from 1952 to 1962, had worked as an organizer of the Community Service Organization (CSO). Padilla, also born in the United States, had worked in the fields before serving in the army and collaborated with Chavez in CSO. Huerta, born in New Mexico and a college graduate, had also worked with Chavez in the CSO but had never worked in the fields. Hernandez, Terronez, and Orendain had all immigrated from Mexico and worked in the fields. This core team also consulted with a set of informal advisors that included two members of the clergy, union allies, political allies, and others. The strategizing thus drew on the salient experiences of a strategically appropriate set of people embedded within both primary and secondary constituencies.

Question 2: What Is the Change They Want/Need?

Developing effective organizing strategy starts with a focus on the change our people really want and need. We may ask first, after doing some relationship building, what do you experience as the “problem”? All our people, some of our people, some more than others? What does it actually look like? Second, what could the world look like if the problem were to be solved; how would your lives be different, specifically? Third, why hasn’t anyone solved the problem? Who is deciding how things are? Who is benefiting? Who is losing? And finally, fourth, what would it take to solve the problem? More education? More information? More counselling More data? More power?

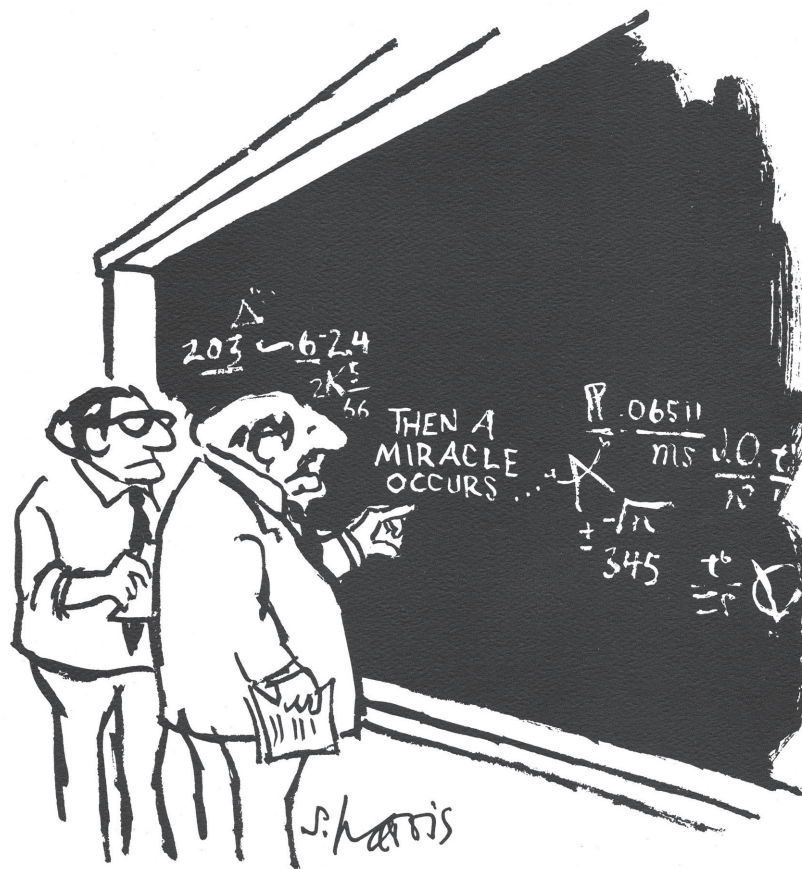
For three years before the strike, Chavez and his colleagues had been organizing a farmworkers’ association to enable farmworkers to begin building *power with* each other by constructing enough solidarity, interdependence, and trust within the local farmworker community to hold people together when it came to the strike. Farmworker families had many needs: higher wages, access to health care, adequate housing, freedom from

abuse on the job, help with social needs like immigration, welfare, traffic tickets, and so forth. The overwhelming belief was that a union could help solve all these problems. But the community also was experiencing the fear, uncertainty, and discrimination that goes with powerlessness. So the initial needs the association addressed were a death benefit, a credit union, help with employment problems, and a newspaper. But the deeper needs evident in these immediate concerns were for the security, dignity, and well-being that could only come with a union powerful enough to make it happen. This would mean challenging the *power over* them held by the growers. Although the strike's wage goal was \$1.40 per hour, other goals of health insurance and job security were equally important. The bottom line, however, was union recognition and a multi-year signed contract with the employers that could consolidate the shift in power not only to win but to grow, sustain, and extend that power. As Bob Dylan sang in "It's Alright, Ma," "If you're not busy being born you're busy dying."

Sometimes a community wants what is only one part of a larger change they need. It is not enough to recognize that a community suffers from institutionalized racism. Organizing members of that community to take an active part in solving the problem depends on their plausible belief that their action could yield results. That it could be worth it. If that possibility is rooted in their own experience, so much the better. They own the solution, not someone else. The genius of the Montgomery Bus Boycott, for example, was that it did not claim to be launching an assault on institutionalized racism but rather focused specifically on the condition of riding on a segregated bus. People's anger over the daily disrespect of a segregated bus could be focused on a plausible solution for which people could fight: a desegregated bus. Had the fight been won with a lawsuit, the community might well have benefited but would not have been empowered. Instead, by organizing a boycott, they transformed an individual's dependency on the bus company to get to work into the bus company's dependency on a united community to survive financially. It turned out that everyone did have an individual resource that could be turned into collective power—their feet. The Montgomery Bus Boycott sparked a movement. By using the resources they had to tackle a "first face of power" (the bus) problem, they did so in a way that set the stage for dealing with the second face of power (legalized Jim Crow) as well as beginning to build the power they would need to tackle the "third face of power" (institutionalized racism) and everything in between. We're still working on that one!

Question 3: What Is Their Theory of Change?

A theory of change is a hypothesis that if we were to do this, that would happen, because. . . . Alas, as the example of the two professors shows, this is often the part left out in practice, not only creating a logic gap (lacuna?) between tactics we choose and outcomes we hope for . . . and miracles rarely happen.



"I THINK YOU SHOULD BE MORE EXPLICIT HERE IN STEP TWO."

Figure 4.3 Then a Miracle Occurs. Copyright © 2005 by Sidney Harris

Sometimes articulation of a theory of change only emerges from analysis of the kind of change really needed—or trial and error—as in the above examples. This is why learning how to learn is such a pivotal leadership practice. Strategizing is inherently iterative, proceeding only rarely in a linear way. The challenge is one of learning how to do something that hasn't been done before—at least in this context, at this time, by these people. Far more useful than being guided by a “best practices” approach—“best” in one context can be “worst” in another—is learning how to devise a practice “best” for this context.

So, what became the theory of change at which strategists of the UFW or Montgomery Bus Boycott arrived? As is so often the case when it comes to organizing, they both arrived at a power theory of change. A power theory of change requires asking: (1) What are our needs? (2) Who holds the resources to meet our needs? (3) What are their needs? and (4) What resources do we have that they need (Figure 1.4).

If our interests are aligned and our resources sufficient, we may choose to create more power “with” each other through collaboration, for example, a credit union or a co-op. But if others hold resources that we need, one source of their power “over” us and our interest's conflict, we must figure out how to use our resources to make it more costly for them to resist the change we seek than to accept it.

In terms of a hypothesis: If we (1) deploy the resources we have in this way in this place at this time, (2) we can affect the needs of others whose resources we need (3) such that it will be more costly for them to deny us access to those resources than to provide them, (4) then we get the resources we need to achieve goals consistent with our interests.

Lest this seem obvious, other theories of change, most of which ignore power, seem more popular in recent years: we can achieve the change we need with better education, more information, transparent information, better data analysis, more robust moral suasion, more compelling storytelling, better access to mental health, more entrepreneurs, a stronger work ethic, more “impact” philanthropy, and so on. Some of these approaches can be useful, but more as forms of support for our people than influencing those holding power them. Based on formal and informal power analysis, these movement strategists decided they would not get the change they needed by trying to persuade those holding power to share it unless it were in their interests to do so. Unless they could find a way to make it more costly (economic, political, moral) for those who hold power to resist change than to

accept it, nothing would change. They had to turn the tables on those holding power “over” them to achieve the change they needed.

A good first step is to create a power map. People do this in different ways, but it is about coming up with a way to visualize the connections among all the “actors” with a connection to the problem in term of their own interests and their resources. For example, in the farmworker case, this included growers, labor contractors, supervisors, and landlords, as well as the farmworkers themselves. What did their terms of interdependence look like. The workers depend on the growers for employment, the growers depend on the workers if they are to have anything to sell. Now taking these interdependencies into consideration, you can hypothesize who is likely to have an interest in the change, who is likely to oppose the change, who might be neutral, who might be of potential support, who may be in potential opposition, what role people in the media may have, what role the courts may have, and so on.

Here’s one example of what a power map can look like (Figure 4.4). One can start by making a posit for every relevant actor, labeling it with that actor’s relevant resources and interests. Then, based on an examination of

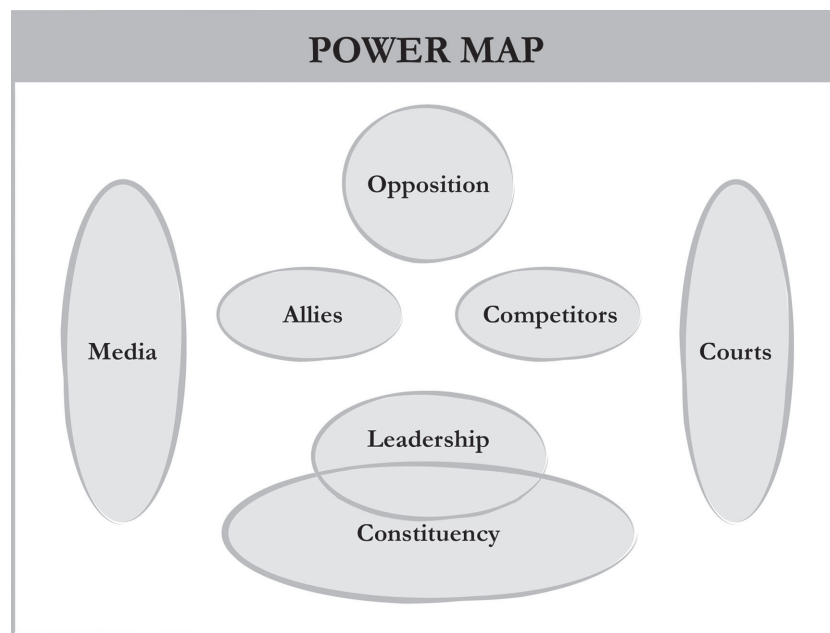


Figure 4.4 Power Map. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

any interdependencies among the actors (who needs whose resources), one can place the posit in the appropriate circle.

At the base is one's constituency—the people who both experience the need for change and whose resources can build the power to create that change. Overlapping the constituency is a leadership team drawn primarily from within the constituency, but which may include others as well (lawyer, researcher, educator, organizer).

Immediately opposite the constituency is the opposition: actors whose interest in maintaining the status quo may be in sharp conflict with those of a constituency in need of change. Particular actors may pass in or out depending on how the campaign evolves.

To the side are actors whose interests may be allied with or in competition with those of the constituency. A neighborhood association, for example, could be allied with an affordable housing group or, if committed to being the only voice of the community, could be a competitor.

And on either side are actors whose resources may or may not be relevant to the campaign, depending on how the leadership chooses to interact with them.

On one side is the legal system, represented by the courts. In some cases, as in the bus boycott, the organizers decided to mobilize the authoritative resources of the courts by filing a suit to desegregate the buses. On the other hand, history is replete with examples of local, state, and federal courts breaking strikes, suppressing demonstrations, and, of course sending people to jail on dubious grounds.

On the other side are the media of communication which on the one hand, may offer a key opportunity to share information, elicit support, and focus attention, and, on the other to publicize vulnerabilities, strengthen the opposition, and, of course, share “fake news.” One way to approach this is to see the media itself as an organizing project, building relationships with the journalists, and others. Cesar Chavez's rule was never do something for the press but, rather, skillfully open a window on what you are doing. Rather than give a press conference, he was available on the picket line.

For this analysis Lukes's Three Faces of Power frame work can be very helpful.¹⁴ It was very clear who the winner and the losers were in terms of the first face of power (who wins, who loses): the grower controls access to work, the worker needs access to work. There were many more workers than

jobs. Or even more proximately the labor contractor who worked for the grower really did the hiring. Again, more workers than contractors, enabled the contractors to elicit bribes, demand favors, understate wages, and so on.

But if we look at it through the lens of the second face of power—who decides—we see how the growers' exercise power at that level too: funding political candidates, deciding who can be mayor, exchanging favors with the county sheriff, exchanging favors with the local judges, even check the local archbishop from supporting the strikers. Before the strike, farmworkers had no leverage in this domain.

We get an even clearer picture if we try to identify the third face of power—who is benefiting, who is losing, and how these fits into the overall scheme of things. Agricultural workers had no access to federal labor law, as they were excluded in 1935 when it was passed. Most workers were not citizens and had no direct access to political power; many were resident aliens and others had no papers at all. Most farmworkers were people of color barred from influence and access in all the ways race has been institutionalized. And so forth. This analysis, however, is not too distant because it too may reveal points of leverage not accessible at a local level.

Question 4: What Is Their Strategic Goal?

Having done enough of the analysis to have arrived at a possibly functional theory of change, we ask how this theory of change can enable us focus on specific strategic goals: outcomes that are visible, measurable, each creating new capacity for achieving a larger goal.

Chavez began with a focus on his own people: workers who, like most people, wanted security, dignity, well-being, and a future for their children. Who held the resources needed to address those interests? It turned out the workers themselves did, in fact, have more resources than many assumed that they could combine to create enough power with each other to address some of their interests (loans, for example) And, indeed, the initial farm worker organizing plan was that it would take five years to create a self-supporting association of farmworkers focused on specific benefits: a death benefit, a credit union, and other forms of mutual aid.

But this wouldn't be enough to address their deepest needs When it came to wages, hours, working conditions, and the like, their employers controlled these resources, with some support from local, county, and state government.

Look at what was at stake for the employers: the growers wanted to maintain stability and control; they wanted a labor force to harvest the grapes; they wanted to profit from their sales and to lower costs. Knowing this, did our constituency hold resources that could affect their employers' needs or interests. The farmworkers controlled their labor, their hands, their time, their skill, their experience, their relationships, their faith, and their cultural identities.

Finally, the strategic question: How could the farmworkers use these resources to affect their employers' interests enough to cause their employers to use their resources to respond to our constituency's needs? In other words, how could the farmworkers make it more costly for the growers to resist their claims than to accede to them? This led to one of the first ways in which the UFW turned its theory of change into a specific strategic objective: "If we withdraw our labor, it will cost our employers more than if they were to give us what we want, so we will organize a strike for as long as it takes to get what we want." The UFW strike was the farmworkers' first attempt to use their resources to affect their employers' interests. But when that wasn't sufficient, the UFW began to identify other resources they could use to impact their employers, indirectly if not directly. They could call on the American public, already sensitized to calls for racial justice, to offer economic support to the strikers. They would learn that they could put political pressure on the growers through state agencies. They could use the law to fill jails, which would cost the county money, which would put indirect pressure on local governments. And they could ask the public not to buy what the employers were selling.

This is where the secondary constituency comes in, a second set of people to be organized. In addition to the farmworkers, the UFW began to organize support committees, first in cities in California, but over time, elsewhere. The farmworkers, now acting as organizers instead of laborers, could use their moral authority and cultural affinity with urban supporters to expand their resource base. These communities could raise money, collect food, and bring other forms of support to the strikers. But while this support enabled the picket lines to persist, it didn't increase their wages or improve their working conditions.

A second major strategic goal then emerged as the strike continued without clear results: boycott Schenley Industries to cost them enough to compel them to recognize the union, sign a contract, and improve wages, hours, and working conditions and, at the same time, show the workers, their

allies, the public—and the growers—that it could be done. This breakthrough came when civil rights activists suggested looking at a boycott. At first, the idea seemed absurd. Table grapes don't carry grower labels, and the season was already over. But the researchers soon learned that Schenley Industries, a New York-based liquor company, owned 4,000 acres of wine grapes in Delano. And Schenley, it turned out, marketed wines and liquors with labels like Cutty Sark scotch. So, starting in November, volunteers were dispatched to major cities to set up picket lines in front of liquor stores, asking customers to shun Schenley. The grape season may have ended, but holiday cocktail parties had just begun.

At the same time, the UFW's leaders focused on the interests of another actor, Edmund G. "Pat" Brown, the first Democrat to serve as California's governor since the 1930s. Brown, who was facing an election, could use his influence on the political, financial, and public interests of the agribusiness industry, its leaders, and their funding; tax policy; water policy; and, more generally, his influence with the broader public.

This was how strategic goals were being crafted, rooted always in a power theory of change and evolving to respond to new obstacles, new opportunities, and new learning. By the time of the meeting of February 1966, described earlier, the UFW's theory of change had focused on a five-year strategic goal to enable farmworkers to build power with each other, based on an analysis that suggested past campaigns had failed because they attempted to strike (mobilize) and organize at the same time. So they began by creating a death benefit, a credit union, and a newspaper: ways to build the solidarity, the sense of hope, and the experience of efficacy that could hold people together in a strike. However, when a rival labor organization called a strike, but only to demand higher wages, the UFW decided to support the strike rather than become strikebreakers. Now the two unions focused on the economic power of workers, as expressed by the strike, and on winning public support for the struggle. The Schenley boycott offered a breakthrough, so the goals could be summarized as winning the boycott, sustaining the strike, and building a support organization rooted in faith communities, the labor movement, political leadership, and the general public.

I turn now to focus on implementation of the campaign goal that came out of that meeting: a march to Sacramento to arrive on Easter Sunday.

The effectiveness of the UFW's strategy lay in finding multiple venues (economic, political, cultural) in which to create the power to make it costly for

the employers to resist union recognition. Success came not from persuading the growers of the justice of their cause, the humanity of their workers, or the potential benefits of collaborating with a union. It came from turning resources the farmworkers had into the power they needed to give the growers an interest in recognizing the union.

In selecting a strategic goal on which to focus a campaign, consider the five features of an effective strategic goal:

- Focuses resources on a single outcome that may enable you to achieve greater outcomes.
- Enables your constituency to translate its resources into power, generating greater capacity.
- Leverages your constituency's strength and the weakness of the opposition.
- Is visible, significant, and important enough to motivate your constituency's engagement.
- Is contagious and can be emulated.

The more concrete, imaginable, and specific the goal, the more clearly you, and others whom you hope to engage, can focus your creativity on achieving it. No action will take shape absent motivation. In narrative terms, our strategic goal becomes a critical part of our story of now. We are faced with an urgent challenge, we look for hope we can meet the challenge, and we commit to a course of action, our strategic goal. Hope inspires both in terms of the values in which it is rooted and as a pathway to possibility.

When checking possible goals against these criteria, don't be afraid to brainstorm, come up with outlandish ideas, or change course. Then you must choose. Commit to the goal that you believe is most likely to enable you to mobilize your resources (what you have) in as powerful a way as possible (what you need) to achieve that goal (what you want). There is no perfect choice. This is why strategy is hard. As Cesar Chavez used to say, "It's not so much making the right decision, as it is making the decision that you make the right decision." Once you're satisfied with your strategic goal, you are ready summarize in a single organizing sentence: "We are organizing [who] to [what outcome] through [how] by [when]." This clarity of focus, almost like a DNA, is not meant to oversimplify. But it is meant to clarify so we can use it in many different contexts to strategize with coherence, coordination, and a broad range of learning opportunities.

In the UFW case described earlier, the leadership decided to build a campaign focused on the goal of marching to Sacramento by Easter Sunday. The theory was that the march could publicize the Schenley boycott, put pressure on the governor to intervene, and organize farmworkers across the state to support the UFW, support the strike, and not come to Delano to work when the season resumed. This goal, in turn, was nested with the broader goals of achieving justice for farmworkers by building a farmworkers' union, getting recognition from the employers, making it more costly to the employers to resist than to agree, conducting a successful boycott, pressuring the governor, and building farmworker support. The brilliance of the march as a goal was that it combined the three higher-level measures of impact—achieving the goal, strengthening the organization, and building leadership—within a single very specific goal, thus focusing effort rather than diffusing it, simplifying rather than complexifying. And as an organizing campaign, its impact could be evaluated by asking whether the strategic goal was achieved, whether the union came out of it stronger, and whether leadership was being developed who could deepen and broaden the movement.

Question 5: What Tactics Can They Use?

A tactic is a way in which your theory of change turns into specific activities. Tactics are activities targeted in specific ways and carried out at specific times, through which your strategy becomes real. Strategy without tactics is just a bunch of nice ideas, and tactics without strategy are a waste of resources. The art of organizing is in the dynamic relationship between strategy and tactics, using the strategy to inform the tactics, and learning from the tactics to adapt strategy.

Strategizing involves an ongoing creative stream of tactical innovation and adaptation as circumstances change, opportunities emerge, and reverses are suffered. A laundry list of “what we are going to try” is not a strategy. It is, at best, a list of possible activities. They only become tactics when enacting your theory of change. Channeling possible activities into three or four pathways, such as fundraising, outreach, and research, does not constitute a strategy unless anchored to a specific goal to which you have committed. Once you have a list of possible activities you need to develop a set of criteria to assess them as tactics. Here are a few ideas:

- Make the most of your own resources, as distinct from those of your opponent.
- Operate with the experience of your constituency, outside that of your opponent.
- Choose tactics that unify your constituency while dividing your opposition.
- Choose tactics that are consistent with your values.
- Choose tactics that are fun, motivational, and simple.

The tactical creativity in support of the UFW's strategic goal was perhaps its greatest strength. Framing the action as a pilgrimage, not simply a march, and timing it for Lent gave it a deeply motivational element and rooted it in the faith of the constituency, providing a values-based motivation for the core constituency. Moving outward from the workers themselves, the pilgrimage presented an opportunity to organize local communities, who welcomed the march on the edge of town with a farmworker committee and musicians. The local committee then accompanied the pilgrims through town, always ending up at a park where there would be food, rest, and a rally in the evening, at which local farmworkers would be asked to join in signing the Plan de Delano. In the morning, a priest would lead a Roman Catholic mass, during which the banner of Our Lady of Guadalupe would be handed off to a worker from that town to carry it to the next.

Media tactics included a press center in a VW van that accompanied the march, staffed by a volunteer press person (borrowed from SNCC), and equipped with phones (it was 1966). Stories went out daily as to the progress of the march and special events. The press center hosted journalists who wanted to interview Chavez, interview farmworkers, or come along for the march. This publicity helped create the momentum and scale as the march proceeded north.

As the march progressed, boycott organizers across the country used a variety of tactics to increase the pressure on Schenley with picket lines, interviews, vigils, and fasts. At the same time, negotiating tactics included back-channel talks mediated by a labor leader who had a shared interest in getting it settled, a long association with the company, and wanted to participate in making a historic event happen. Simultaneously, talks were going on with the governor, motivating his engagement and asking him to be at the Capitol to welcome the marchers. Although in the end Governor Brown

rejected this request, electing to spend Easter in Palm Springs with his friend Frank Sinatra, this affront to the Latino community may have contributed to his loss to Ronald Reagan later that year.

Question 6: What about Timing?

Campaigns unfold within “time as an arrow.” As I discuss further in chapter six, the term was coined by paleontologist Stephen J. Gould, a student of deep time, inspired by the Greek distinction between *kairos*—exactly the right moment—and *chronos*—incremental passage of time.¹⁵ Gould adapted this perspective into what he called “time as an arrow”—the rhythm of change—and “time as a cycle”—the rhythm of continuity. Campaigns start in one place with the goal of ending up in another place: intense focus, high risk, a clear start date, clear ending date, moving from peak to peak to peak, growing the power to overcome resistance and win. In contrast, organizations construct a rhythm of continuity with routines, regular reviews, annual budgets, and so forth.

Given the pace at which campaigns unfold, sensitive to the need for on-going adaptation, scholars of “entrainment” argue the need for a “temporal strategy” by paying attention to the temporal environment in which we operate. Time external to the campaign is structured as seasons, semesters, work rhythms, electoral rhythms, news cycles, weekends, holidays, and more. Time internal to the campaign is structured by the need to build momentum by meeting specific goals and to do so at specific times. The campaign timeline also has to recognize the time frame within which one’s constituency lives. For example, we ought not to try starting a campaign after the season is half over or schedule a meeting for a weekend when everyone may take their families out of town. Timing a campaign strategically requires situating it within each of these temporal dimensions.¹⁶

Temporal strategy also requires alignment of the above with the inherent dynamics of a campaign. When is the right time for a kickoff? How much time will it take to reach a first peak? When is it time to make a change? When will participants need time off, even as the campaign moves on? And when, how, and by whom are temporal decisions made?

Momentum requires establishing and maintaining the initiative by expecting that every action you take will produce a reaction to which you have already considered how to respond. It also means never concluding one

activity until it is clear how it will lead to the next one. You need to commit your people to what comes next when they are still there together.

It may also be strategic to structure a campaign around a date of inherent significance for your constituency. The UFW wisely chose to align its march with the Lenten Easter season. The clear and deep cultural resonance of the pilgrimage with farmworkers' faith even made the action meaningful to those of other faith traditions. Perhaps it also afforded an educational opportunity for those without a faith grounding. It also created a natural campaign peak for the final week, beginning on Palm Sunday, moving through the Stations of the Cross, Good Friday, Saturday Vigil, and Easter Sunday. Nor was the Easter narrative incidental, as it tells a story of suffering, sacrifice, hope, and redemption.

The timing of the march also tied in with more prosaic, but important, dates in California's political calendar. The Senate committee's decision to hold a hearing in Delano, combined with a special effort to get Senator Kennedy there, provided the perfect opportunity to announce that the march would start the next morning. This tactic turned out to be especially valuable when the Delano police tried to stop the march with a line that resembled the police response in Selma. The image of the police line told a powerful visual story about the connections between what was going on in California and Alabama.

And then there's the sense of timing in dealing with actions and reaction. When I was with the UFW in 1967, we had organized a strike of Giumarra Vineyard, the largest grape grower in the industry. As the strike got hobbled by court injunctions, recruitment of strike breakers, and more, we tried to focus a boycott targeting particularly Giumarra's table grapes. It was hard enough trying to enable consumers to identify whose grapes were whose, but we had had some success following trucks and railcars to identify which stores to picket. Before long, however, the other growers began lending Giumarra their labels, so there was no way to figure out which was which. At first, we did not know how to deal with this disruption to our strategy. Fred Ross saw the opportunity. What if we simply boycotted all table grapes? Then we could tackle the industry as a whole, rather than through piecemeal boycotts, a strategy that gave them the advantage. This insight led to the grape boycott that eventually brought the entire industry under union contract.

The capacity to align our initial strike strategy with the peak of the table grape season not only had an impact on the grower, raising his costs substantially, but it also brought a whole new cohort of workers into the union. So,

at the end of the season, in October, when the focus shifted to the cities, we had the people, the leadership, and renewed commitment—and the time—to build local boycott organizations in time to be ready to “stop the grapes” in May at the start of the 1969 season.

Conclusion

In organizing, strategizing combines creativity, analysis, and timing in a very symbiotic and dynamic way. Strategy is rooted in the constituency whose centrality to the strategy is a source of their empowerment. A diverse, informed, and agile leadership team must center the resources, interests, and needs of this constituency in strategizing campaigns that can turn what you have into what you need to get what you want. Effective strategy requires clarity on the overarching change at stake. The why and the how are linked in one’s theory of change, which must in turn be based on a solid power analysis. Focusing on a specific goal enables the most strategic use of resources. Achieving clarity as to the goal and the theory of change enables leaders to generate creative, relevant, and motivational tactics within a rhythm of change that is aligned with what’s going on both in the world and in the constituency.

If we look back at the UFW campaign, using our three impact criteria—achieving our goal, strengthening our organization, building our leadership—surely it accomplished all three. In terms of goals, the farmworkers won their first contract, the governor got productively involved, and the organizing campaign broke through as a social movement to the public. In terms of capacity, the UFW came out of it far stronger than when it went in, with more members, greater organizing capacity, and lots of learning. In terms of leadership, the campaign developed new leaders in both the farmworker towns and boycott cities, provided opportunities for current leaders to stretch their skills as march coordinators and advance organizers, and allowed the strategic leadership team to test out its ability to move quickly, with focus, follow-through, and communication.

Any campaign that seeks to achieve long-term, meaningful change must have an effective strategy. But strategy without action is all talk. In the next chapter, we turn to the nuts and bolts of action, where change happens.